
A New Netflix Show Combines Two of TV's Most Popular Showrunners and a Dream Cast. It Does Not Go Well.

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Given that they've built a career on emulating Steven Spielberg's direction, it makes sense that Matt and Ross Duffer would mark the end of [Stranger Things](#) by following him into the realm of executive producing. They've already stuck their imprimatur on the Netflix series *Something Bad Is Going to Happen* and the animated spinoff *Stranger Things: Tales From '85*, and now comes *The Boroughs*, a slowly unwinding creeper set in a desert retirement community. Creators Jeffrey Addiss and Will Matthews, who created the *Dark Crystal* series *Age of Resistance* and co-wrote the animated movie *The Lord of the Rings: The War of the Rohirrim*, are aiming less for Spielberg than for his derivatives, especially the movies produced under his Amblin banner in the 1980s: Think of it as *Gremlins* meets *The Goonies*, with a sizable helping of *Cocoon*. (That last one wasn't made by Amblin, but like *The Boroughs*, it plays as if it wishes it were.)

There's also, inevitably, a lot of *Stranger Things*, if you aged up the characters about 60 years. Like Hawkins, Indiana, the Boroughs presents as an idyllic, tight-knit community, a place where, as the slogan plastered on every flat surface reminds us, "you'll have the time of your life." But underneath its facade is—would you believe it?—a dark and deadly secret that the people who guard it will stop at nothing to keep hidden. And a ragtag group of friends, in this case thrown together more by circumstance than by inclination, are the only ones who can uncover the truth.

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While the Duffers' own show relied on finding fresh faces, *The Boroughs*' cast is a dream team of screen veterans: Alfred Molina as Sam, a retired scientist who moves in after the death of his wife (Jane Kaczmarek, seen in flashbacks); Denis O'Hare as his quirky neighbor Wally; Alfre Woodard and Clarke Peters as Judy and Art, a once idealistic couple whose open marriage has allowed them to drift further and further apart; and Geena Davis as Renee, who hasn't let age or circumstances dull her appetite for life, or sex. It's a particular joy to see Woodard, who of late has been wasted in too many things, like the Z-grade remake of *Salem's Lot*, get a chance to stretch out a character over eight full episodes. But the series' writing is rarely up to the level of its actors, and Woodard in

particular gets shortchanged by a character arc that runs all the way from morose to glum.

I can't give away the Boroughs' secret here, but thanks to the obligatory scare that opens the show, the one that's meant to convince streaming viewers they shouldn't immediately scroll onward, I can say there's a monster involved, a leathery creature that plucks old people from their beds and suggests that "the time of your life" might not be that long after all. Sam's already having cognitive issues, moments when his wife's death seems to be happening in the present instead of the past, over and over again. But as one of the Boroughs' employees chirpily informs him, getting older isn't trauma. Your life isn't supposed to be a full or happy one at this point: Just play some pickleball, maybe take an exercise class, and wait for the end.

The show means, I guess, to show us there's still life in these old folks: They still smoke weed, get laid, and remain a lot more aware of their surroundings than the unnervingly buoyant couple who run the Boroughs, Blaine (Seth Numrich) and Anneliese (Alice Kremelberg), are counting on. But its vision of life's final chapter feels thin, as if the people making the show didn't talk to any older people in the process. (Call your parents, folks.) Among the writing staff, the closest to the characters' ages is James Schamus, who pops in for a single credit on the sixth episode but leaves no trace of the Oscar-nominated screenwriter behind *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon*. There's no reason you have to have been through the aging process to tell stories about it, but it requires a curiosity and compassion the series rarely employs, interested more in its unfolding mystery and the occasional joke about fried food.

That might be more forgivable if *The Boroughs'* central mystery were more engaging or less predictable—or even vaguely coherent. But it's a mess, constantly shifting what it seems to be about—a magic tree? An alien egg?—in ways that create confusion rather than a sense of intrigue. There are ways to leave the door open for future seasons that aren't just playing hide-the-ball, but this feels less like calculated suggestion and more like simple vagueness; if anyone knows where this is going, there's no sign of it. The show does occasionally, if not for long, capture the vibe of some of those Spielberg-produced '80s classics (although a lot of those, to be frank, struggle to retain that status when viewed through adult eyes). But that's in no small part because the show so often treats its elderly protagonists like children, motivated only by the parts of their characters it's chosen to show us thus far. It's not interested in the lives they lived before, and they're not interesting enough for us to wonder.

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